

FACTORIES ARE LITERALLY DEATH TRAPS

THE TRIANGLE SHIRTWAIST
FACTORY FIRE (1911)



IN CONTEXT

FOCUS

Employment law

BEFORE

1900 An average of 100 people die every day in industrial accidents across the US.

1909 Thousands of garment workers strike for improved conditions. Larger companies, such as the Triangle Shirtwaist Company, reject demands for increased workplace safety.

AFTER

1933 President Roosevelt's New Deal places social and workplace reform at the heart of government policy.

1940 The amended Fair Labor Standards Act cuts the work week in the US to 40 hours. Other US workers' rights won in the years after the Triangle Shirtwaist Factory fire include sick leave, safety precautions, and child labor laws.

Until the 9/11 terrorist attacks on the World Trade Center, the Triangle Shirtwaist Factory fire of March 25, 1911, was the single most serious loss of life in New York City. Almost all of the 146 who died were young immigrant women, predominantly Jewish and Italian, trapped when a fire spread through the top three floors of the Greenwich Village building where they worked. All were seamstresses paid between \$7 and \$12 for a 52-hour, 6-day week and forced to endure overcrowded and exploitative conditions. Their deaths were the result of a combination of municipal indifference and incompetence